Receding glaciers and bird migration

When the last glacial period began to end, around 26,500 years ago, Earth was much colder than it is today. Much of North America and northern Eurasia was covered with ice sheets. The environment was so harsh that most birds tended to live in subtropical and tropical regions where there was more food.

As temperatures began rising, the ice sheets started to shrink, uncovering a new landscape. Ice-free ground and short, wet summers were ideal for insects, and birds began to move in, too, to take advantage of this food supply. When days got shorter in fall, some birds stayed on for the winter, but others returned south.

The distances flown by birds returning to their homes grew longer as the ice sheets retreated farther, eventually developing into long-distance spring and fall migrations between the tropics and northern latitudes. Common birds that undertake the journey include swallows, warblers, and cuckoos.